



THE MORAL IMPERATIVES OF CHANGE

"Compassion will show the way"

DALAI LAMA SPIRITUAL LEADER

The challenge of change to me is tied to the Buddhist concept of time: That time never stands still, it changes every moment. No force can stop that movement. The only thing that is up to us is how we utilise time—in a constructive or a destructive way. Because of the nature of time, a new reality is being forged every moment. But there's often a gap between reality and our perception of change. When we stick to our old perceptions and take action on its basis—even with the best of motivations—they simply don't fit the new reality. And the methods used become unrealistic, failing to bring the desired results.

My life experience has shown me the truth of this. I am nothing special, just a simple human being, a Buddhist monk. I come from a very remote village, from a simple family of farmers. My mother was illiterate but a very kind and affectionate woman. At that time, I didn't really appreciate kindness as a value—I often took advantage of it and bullied her. But today I feel that experience is most firmly imprinted on my mind, especially as a practitioner of Buddhism.

I grew up at a time when there was immense suffering in the world. In the year of my birth, 1935, there was the Nazi rising. And then came the Second World War. Millions of people suffered and died. When I look back, I realise, during the 1930s and 1940s in Europe people fought and killed over issues of sovereignty and a clear demarcation between the idea of "we" and "they". The devastations occurred not just due to lack of education, absence of science and technology or poor economy. But behind unthinkable destruction, be it a September 11 or the Mumbai attacks, there is always an agency of a smart brain—intelligence guided by human hatred and driven by modern technology.

They happen because we lack a sense of global responsibility on the basis of affection, brotherhood and the inability to look at one

another as just one species—human beings. The reality today is that every nation's future depends on the rest of the world. The old concept of "we" and "they" doesn't hold anymore. The former enemies in Europe have today formed the European Union. Look at the blood-bath in Stalinist Soviet Union, or Mongolia of the 1930s, when hundreds of monasteries were destroyed and more than 1,00,000 monks were killed. All that suffering in the name of faith is today giving way to a new spirit, and faith is rapidly reviving in both. Consider the global environmental problem. There's an increasing recognition that even the most powerful nations cannot solve the problem, unless the whole world works together. You must consider others as a part of yourself. And all disagreement and differing interests have to be resolved through talk, not by force. This is our new reality.

The time has come to be guided, not by history, technology, smart brains, suspicion, distrust or hatred, but by love, compassion, the spirit of reconciliation and the determination to open up dialogue. For that, we need inner strength. In my life, what I find very helpful is my sense of compassion and brotherhood, which come from my mother. Whenever she saw a needy person, she would give away anything available in the kitchen. As time passed, I developed the conviction that our inner values, warmth, heartedness, compassion, that clear spirit of

"INDIA HAS A FAR GREATER CHANCE TO PROMOTE DEEPER HUMAN VALUES FOR A HAPPIER SOCIETY, SECULARLY."

DALAI LAMA